

Family and Society in Islam

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بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم

Foundation of social harmony in Islam

- Social fabric begins with the lawful relationship between man and woman (An-Nisā': 1)
- Created from one soul — unity and interconnectedness
- Allah placed affection and mercy between spouses (Ar-Rūm: 21)
- Rooted in the permission of Allah سبحانه وتعالى



Origin of Male–Female Interaction

- Humanity created from one soul
- Man and woman are:
  - Interconnected
  - Complementary
- Types of Cross-Gender Interaction
  - **For need (collegial or work)** — for noble endeavors (knowledge, work, charity, jihad, sale-purchase) — permissible with conditions
  - **Friendship** —maintained within the same gender; cross-gender friendship virtually impossible within limits prescribed by Islam
  - **Sila Rahim** – where men and women are required to take care of their families and maintain family ties; it is obligatory with observing proper manners and etiquettes of interaction.
  - **Love** — must be channeled toward marriage
- **Infatuation born and sustained in darkness ends only in deeper darkness**



Etiquettes in Interactions with the Opposite Gender in Islam



Etiquettes of Speaking to Opposite Gender

Speaking to a non-mahram woman may occur because of a need or it may occur needlessly. If it is done needlessly and only for fun and enjoyment, then there is no doubt, it is haram and comes under the heading of the zina of the tongue and ears about which the Prophet (Pbuh) said: “The son of Adam’s share of zina (adultery) has been decreed for him, which he will inevitably get. The zina of the eyes is looking, the zina of the ears is listening, the zina of the tongue is speaking, the zina of the hands is touching, and the zina of the foot is walking. The heart longs and wishes, and the private part confirm that or deny it.” (Sahih al-Bukhari).



Etiquettes of Speaking to Opposite Gender

When there is a need to speak to a woman, the basic principle is that it is permissible, but it is essential to pay attention to the following etiquette:

- The conversation should be limited to only what is necessary, without talking too much or branching off into other topics.
- Avoiding joking and laughing; that is not part of etiquette and dignity.
- Avoid staring and always trying hard to lower the gaze as much as possible; if there is a quick glance for the purpose of speaking, there is nothing wrong with that.



Etiquettes of Speaking to Non-Mahram

- Not softening the voice by either party or choosing soft words; rather they should speak is the same, ordinary tone of voice as they would speak to anyone else.
- Avoiding the use of any words that may have some suggestive meanings, and so on.
- Not going to extremes in embellishing one's speech. Some people use their skills in communication with others by movements of the hand or face or by quoting poetry or proverbs or romantic phrases. This is a means that the Shaytaan uses to open the door to haram attraction between the sexes.



The Ayah

Allah says in the holy Quran: “Tell the believing men to lower their gaze and guard their private parts. That is purer for them. Lo! Allah is aware of what they do”. (Surah Nur Ayah 30)

This Ayah carries many indications.

- Allah did not mention what the gaze should be lowered from and what the private parts should be protected from, however, this is known by common sense. Sa’id ibn Abi al-Hasan once asked Hasan Al-Basari: ‘Women from non-Muslims nations uncover their chests and heads?’ He said: ‘Avert your gaze, because Allah says: “Tell the believing men to lower their gaze and guard their private parts”.



Dangers of Sight

- Sight is the greatest gateway to the heart, and the most frequently used sense. And accordingly, many falls from grace happens due to this. Therefore, warning against it is essential. It is important to turn your eye away from all forbidden things, rather anything that might cause temptation.
- The Prophet ﷺ said: “Beware of sitting on the roads.” Sahaba asked: “O Messenger of Allah, we gather to talk to each other (in leisure times).” He said: “If you insist on sitting in the streets, then give the road its due right.” They said: “What is the due right of the road, O Messenger of Allah?” He replied: “Lowering the gaze, refraining from causing harm, returning greetings, enjoining what is right, and forbidding what is wrong.”



Rewards of Controling Gaze

- Narrated from Wuhayb ibn al-Ward, who said: “To abandon backbiting is more beloved to me than having the world from the time it was created until the time it perishes, and spending all of it in the path of God. And to lower my gaze is more beloved to me than having the world from the time it was created until the time it perishes, and spending all of it in the path of God.” He then recited: *“Tell the believing men to lower their gaze”* [Quran, An-Nur: 30].

- Sheikh Abu Abd al-Rahman al-Sulami said: I heard my grandfather Ibn Nujayd say: Shah al-Kirmani said: “Whoever lowers his gaze from what is forbidden, restrains himself from desires, cultivates his inner self through constant mindfulness of God, follows the Sunnah in his outward conduct, and accustoms himself to eating only what is lawful — his spiritual discernment will never fail him”.



Rewards of Controling Gaze

- Once Utba bin Ghazwan and Abu Musa al-Ash'ari were on a military expeditions, and a slave girl was unveiled. Ghazwan unintentionally looked at her, so he raised his hand and slapped his eye. He said: "You are looking at what harms you and does not benefit you." He met Abu Musa and asked him, and he said: "You have wronged your eye, so ask God for forgiveness and repent." For the first (unintentional) glance is forgiven, and she bears the responsibility for what comes after that.
- And in Sahih Muslim, Jarir ibn Abdullah asked the Messenger of Allah ﷺ about a sudden glance, and he commanded him to avert his gaze.



- The Nafs is foolish — if it is given free rein in what is lawful and grows accustomed to it, it will slip easily into what is unlawful. The discipline of the soul is to withhold from it even what is lawful, so that it does not grow greedy for what is unlawful. For example, the soul has grown accustomed to the pleasure of speech. If it is not compelled to silence in situations where silence is necessary, until it becomes habituated to restraining itself from unnecessary talk, then the desire for speech will die out, and the person finds rest and gains strength in truthfulness — so that he speaks only what is right. His silence becomes an act of worship, and his speech becomes an act of worship, because when he speaks, he speaks the truth, and when he is silent, he is silent for a rightful reason — out of fear of harm.

- Similarly with the desire of the gaze: the soul grows accustomed to the pleasure of letting the eyes wander freely wherever they fall, without restraint. If the soul is not compelled to lower the gaze in situations where that is necessary — keeping the glance humble and the eyes cast down — it will grow habituated to letting the eyes roam in pursuit of unlawful things. Then, when something forbidden appears before it, it will have no control over its gaze, for the desire of looking will have taken hold of its eyes and mastered them.



- The same applies to the desires of hearing, the hands, the feet, the stomach, and the private parts. The striving here, when a servant resolves to struggle against his Nafs, he has to compel each of these seven limbs to be weaned from its habitual actions — whether lawful or unlawful — until that desire dies. For each of these desires is a single desire: part of it has been made lawful for him, and part has been made unlawful — as a trial from God Almighty for His servants, and as a wise arrangement for them.



- Allah says: “And let them guard their private parts”, meaning they should conceal them from being seen. It has also been said that “And let them guard their private parts” means from guard against adultery. All these meanings are intended, and the wording is general.
- Allah says: “That is purer for them”, meaning that lowering one’s gaze and guarding one’s chastity is purer for Muslim men. The Muslim who guard his gaze from looking at forbidden things will be rewarded his partner in Jannah, according to his own standards of beauty. In this world, he is rewarded with special flavor of worship, and such farsightedness that others lack.
- The believers have the Hereafter before their eyes, so the world with all its two kinds and types has become insignificant in comparison to the Hereafter, so that all the pleasures of the world in their eyes are like the crumbs of food from a great table, and all the hardships of the world in their eyes are like the killing of a criminal or a sinner who deserved to be killed or crucified from all the punishments of the people of the world.



Allah further says in the next Ayah: “And tell the believing women to lower their gaze and guard their private parts, do not display their ornaments except what appears thereof, and to draw their veils over their bosoms, and not to reveal their adornment save to their own husbands or fathers or husbands' fathers, or their sons or their husbands' sons, or their brothers or their brothers' sons or sisters' sons, or their women, or their slaves, or male attendants who lack interest (due to age), or children who know naught of women’s affairs. And let them not stamp their feet so as to reveal what they hide of their adornment. And turn unto Allah together, O believers, in order that ye may succeed”.



Marriage Relationship



Marriage as a Legal Protection

- Marriage is:
  - Binding contract
  - Rights-based system
- Protects:
  - Woman
  - Children
- State enforces rights



Critique of Western Model

- Women forced into workforce due to:
  - Lack of financial support
- Issues:
  - Exploitation
  - Wage inequality
  - Objectification
  - Vulnerability
  - Burden to earn
- Result:
  - Social imbalance
  - Child neglect
  - Family breakdown



Islam's Balanced Vision

- Life seen as:
  - Integrated system
- Roles are:
  - Complementary
  - Cooperative
- Goal:
  - Strong families
  - Stable society



Justice Between the Genders

- Islam assigns responsibilities according to nature and capability
  - Man: provider, financial responsibility, hard labor
  - Woman: pregnancy, childbirth, nursing, nurturing, child-rearing
- Inheritance: man receives double — because he spends it on wife and children
- Woman's inheritance is entirely her own — no obligation to spend on the husband and her kids



Qiwāmah (Guardianship)

- Men are protectors and maintainers of women (An-Nisā': 34)
  - Two reasons: financial responsibility + greater emotional steadiness
  - Women distinguished with deep emotional sensitivity
- Mother's status above father's in child's devotion

